

MAKING A BETTER WORLD

For HUL, sustainability is not just a strategic priority but deeply embedded in its purpose and operations

BY KRISHNA GOPALAN

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► **IN 2010, HINDUSTAN** Unilever Ltd (HUL), as a part of its parent's Unilever Sustainable Living Plan (USLP), looked at ways to address India-specific challenges and opportunities. "We laid out ambitious goals to decouple business growth from environmental impact, while increasing positive social outcomes. It significantly advanced our sustainability agenda in India," says B. P. Biddappa, Executive Director and Chief People Transformation and Sustainability Officer, HUL.

The approach is simple—what is good for India is good for HUL. Sustainability, Biddappa elaborates, is not just a strategic priority but deeply embedded "in our purpose and operations." Before the company really formalised its sustainability and CSR goals, the commitment towards communities and the ecosystem was evident in flagship programmes like Prabhat and Shakti.

At HUL's scale and size (in FY25, it generated a revenue of ₹64,138 crore), there are multiple advantages when it comes to making a significant difference to the sustainability story. Biddappa says the company has sharpened its focus on four priority areas—climate, nature, plastics and livelihoods. "We will scale up our proven models across these pillars, which will help us focus our actions more clearly while driving sustainability across the value chain." From

a consumer's point of view, there was a tilt towards a desire to using more sustainable products, without compromising on performance and affordability. "It was pivotal for us, as India's largest FMCG company, to double down our focus on sustainable practices that would help operational practices and enhance credibility."

One such example has been the shift towards water-efficient manufacturing processes. Here, HUL has redesigned its factories to minimise

water usage and invested in closed-loop systems. "We have not only conserved a critical resource but also significantly reduced utility costs. Another key initiative was the company's early adoption of biomass-based energy solutions at its manufacturing units," says Biddappa. Fossil fuels were replaced with agricultural waste and other renewable sources, leading to HUL cutting down on carbon emissions and supporting local economies that supplied the biomass. HUL's

B. P. BIDDAPPA EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR AND CHIEF PEOPLE TRANSFORMATION AND SUSTAINABILITY OFFICER, HUL



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→ In climate action, HUL has cut Scope 1 and 2 emissions by 98% and reduced its total energy consumption by 45% compared to 2008 levels